THE BULLOCK PRESIDENCY

BOOK ONE: BEFORE

Chapter 8 — "The Fix"

Monday, July 1, 2024 – Saturday, August 10, 2024

COLD OPEN — "THE CURB"

EXT. BALDWIN HILLS — A QUIET RESIDENTIAL STREET — LOS ANGELES — NIGHT

SUPER: MONDAY, JULY 1, 2024 — 11:52 PM PDT

A hillside street of mid-century homes with wide lawns and big views. Jacarandas, their purple blossoms long since fallen, crushed into the asphalt. Porch lights. A sprinkler ticking somewhere.

Two houses side by side. One, a white ranch house with a red door and a basketball hoop that hasn't had a net since 2006. The other, a two-story Spanish colonial where, in 1999, a trampoline was "structurally unsound."

On the curb between the two driveways, two grown men sitting side by side in the dark. Marc-Anthony Bullock (32), presumptive Democratic nominee for President, in a hoodie. Amond Baker (32), in a Bengals t-shirt. Two bottles of ginger ale. A black Secret Service SUV idles at the end of the block, lights off.

Twelve hours ago, the House of Representatives passed the 28th Amendment, 297 to 134. Four hours ago, the Senate followed, 67 to 32. Tonight, for the first time in American history, Congress has sent the states an amendment to the presidential age requirement.

AMOND
Two ninety-seven.

MARC
Two ninety-seven.

AMOND
Sixty-seven in the Senate. With one to spare.

MARC
That senator from the Mountain West. Last vote. He said his granddaughter told him to.

AMOND
Everybody's granddaughter's telling everybody what to do this year.

They sit. The sprinkler ticks.

MARC
It's July.

AMOND
...It's July.

MARC
You told me in Detroit to ask you in July.

AMOND
You told ME to ask YOU in July.

MARC
Same thing.

Marc sets down his ginger ale. Turns to face his best friend. Not joking. For once in his life, completely serious.

MARC
Thirty-eight states haven't ratified it yet. They might not. It might stall at thirty-five. Thirty-six. If it does, and we win, neither of us can serve. The Speaker of the House becomes President. Every smart person in the party is telling me to pick somebody over thirty-five. Shapiro. Whitmer. Wes Moore. Warnock. The Vice President. Somebody safe. Somebody who can be President on January twentieth if this thing falls short.

AMOND
They're right.

MARC
I know they're right.

AMOND
So pick one of them.

MARC
No.

Amond turns to look at him.

MARC
If I pick somebody safe, I'm telling the whole country I don't believe it. That "age shouldn't matter" was just a line for a nine-year-old. That I'll say it on a stage, but I won't bet on it. And Amond, I've bet on everything my whole life. I'm not stopping now.

(beat)
Amond Baker. Will you be my running mate?

Amond looks at him for a long time. Then down at the street. At the crack in the curb where, in 1998, they carved their initials with a

screwdriver. "M.A.B. + A.B." It's still there. Faded.

AMOND
You know what everybody's gonna say. Two thirty-two-year-olds. Two former Bluebird kids. Two actors. A Kid Mayor and his Deputy Mayor.

MARC
I know.

AMOND
They're gonna say it's a joke. A buddy comedy. They're gonna make a movie about it and cast somebody worse than us.

MARC
I know.

AMOND
And if the states don't ratify, Mike Johnson becomes President of the United States because you couldn't pick a grown-up.

MARC
I know.

A long silence.

AMOND
...Okay.

MARC
Okay what?

AMOND
Okay. Yes. Obviously. Idiot.

Marc lets out a breath that sounds like it's been held since April 2023. He laughs. Amond laughs. They hug on the curb, two grown men in hoodies, at midnight, in front of their mothers' houses.

On the porch of the white ranch house, a light comes on. The red door opens. GLORIA BAKER (58), Amond's mother, retired LAUSD fourth-grade teacher, in a bathrobe and a bonnet, steps out onto the porch with her arms crossed.

GLORIA
It is MIDNIGHT. On a SCHOOL night. I can hear y'all from my BEDROOM.

AMOND
Mama, it's July. There's no school.

GLORIA
It's a school night in my HEART, Amond.

(squinting)
Marc-Anthony, is that you?

MARC
Yes ma'am.

GLORIA
What are you two doing out here?

Marc and Amond look at each other.

MARC
...Picking a Vice President, Mrs. Baker.

Gloria stares at them. Then at the Secret Service SUV at the end of the block. Then back at them.

GLORIA
Well, pick him inside. I made a sweet potato pie on Sunday and nobody ate it.

She goes back in, leaving the door open. They get up and follow her, the way they did in 1999.

In the crack in the curb: "M.A.B. + A.B."

Twitter · @AP

BREAKING: Senate passes proposed 28th Amendment lowering the presidential age requirement to 25, sending it to the states. Ratification requires 38 states.

211K Retweets · 690K Likes · 8:19 PM EDT

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

IT PASSED CONGRESS. 297-134. 67-32. ON THE 53RD ANNIVERSARY OF THE 26TH AMENDMENT. NOW 38 STATES. LET'S GO.

92K Retweets · 501K Likes

ACT ONE — "THE SUMMER"

MONTAGE — APRIL 26 TO AUGUST 8, 2024 — HEADLINES, POSTS, AND MOMENTS

THE WASHINGTON POST — FRI, MAY 3

At the White House, Biden and Bullock Share Lunch, a Hug, and a Promise

The President and the presumptive nominee spent two hours together. Bullock left with a gift: Biden's 1972 legal pad, for "the girl with the spreadsheet."

Instagram · @esthersmilleybullock — MAY 3

[Photo: Emma, 11, holding a yellowed 1972 legal pad covered in handwritten vote counts, mouth wide open] Caption: The President sent this home with Marc. Emma has not put it down in six hours. She's sleeping with it.

22.4M likes

— FRIDAY, MAY 10. The twins turn twelve. Victoria demands a "presidential" birthday. She gets one: a cake shaped like the Capitol dome, which Victoria immediately decapitates.

AP — TUE, MAY 14

Bullock clinches Democratic nomination, crossing 1,968 pledged delegates with wins in Maryland, Nebraska, West Virginia

— SATURDAY, MAY 18. Columbia, South Carolina. A small brick church. In the second pew, REP. JAMES CLYBURN (83). Beside him, Marc, in a plain suit, no pin, a notepad on his knee. For two hours, Clyburn talks: about 1960, about lunch counters, about voting, about the church mothers who powered the Biden firewall. Marc doesn't interrupt once. He fills eleven pages. When it's over, Clyburn stands, shakes his hand, and says something nobody else hears. Marc nods. Afterward, asked by reporters about the meeting, Clyburn says only that the young man listened well.

THE NEW YORK TIMES — THU, MAY 30

Trump Convicted on All 34 Counts in Hush Money Trial, First Former President Found Guilty of a Crime

— SUNDAY, JUNE 16, FATHER'S DAY, 4:12 PM PDT. Sunrise Hill, the back terrace. Marc's phone rings. "CORNELIUS SMILLEY." He stares at it. Answers. A long silence on the line. Then a gruff voice: "...Happy Father's Day." Marc says it back. Another silence. Then they talk, haltingly, about the twins, about Lorraine's knee surgery, about the Braves. The call lasts four minutes and twelve

seconds. Neither of them mentions politics once. When Marc hangs up, Esther, in the doorway, has tears in her eyes.

ESTHER
He stayed on the line.

MARC
Four minutes and twelve seconds.

ESTHER
That's longer than he's ever talked to Neil.

POLITICO — JUN 24

Trump Declines to Debate Bullock Until Age Amendment Is Ratified: "I Don't Debate People Who Can't Be President"

THE NEW YORK TIMES — MON, JULY 1

Supreme Court Rules Presidents Have Broad Immunity for Official Acts

THE NEW YORK TIMES — MON, JULY 1

Congress Approves Proposed Amendment Lowering Presidential Age Requirement to 25, Sending It to the States

The vote, on the 53rd anniversary of the 26th Amendment's ratification, followed an intense lobbying push by President Biden and a coalition of 41 House Republicans.

— SATURDAY, JULY 13, 6:11 PM EDT. A campaign rally in Butler, Pennsylvania. Gunshots. Donald Trump clutching his ear, pulled down by Secret Service agents. Then rising, fist in the air, blood on his face. A firefighter in the crowd, Corey Comperatore, is killed shielding his family. Two other people are critically wounded. The gunman is killed by a counter-sniper.

— SATURDAY, JULY 13, 4:02 PM PDT. Sunrise Hill. The family room. Marc, Esther, the twins, frozen in front of the TV. Victoria grabs her father's arm. Emma is shaking. Marc turns off the TV, holds both girls, and then, without a word to anyone, walks into his study and picks up the phone.

— SATURDAY, JULY 13, 6:48 PM PDT / 9:48 PM EDT. Marc's study at Sunrise Hill. We hear only Marc's side, standing, with the door closed.

MARC
(into phone, quiet)
Mr. President. It's Marc-Anthony Bullock. I'm not calling as your opponent. I'm calling to say I'm so sorry, and I'm praying for you, and for the man who died, and his family, and for the two people who were hurt.

(listens)
...Yes, sir. I mean it. Whatever we disagree on, nobody in this country should ever be shot at for running for office. Nobody. Ever.

(listens)
Yes, sir. I'm suspending all campaign events and ads through the convention in Milwaukee. That's the right thing to do.

(listens)
...Thank you, sir. Get some rest.

He hangs up. Stands alone in the study for a long moment. Then he walks back into the family room, where Esther and the girls are waiting, and doesn't let go of them for an hour.

ASSOCIATED PRESS — SUN, JULY 14

Trump wounded in assassination attempt at Pennsylvania rally; one spectator killed. Bullock calls Trump, suspends campaign ads: "Nobody should ever be shot at for running for office."

POLITICO — MON, JULY 15

Trump Picks JD Vance as Running Mate at Republican National Convention in Milwaukee

— TUESDAY, JULY 16, MILWAUKEE. The Fiserv Forum. The Republican National Convention. Among a parade of celebrity speakers, a former child star in a cowboy hat steps to the podium: JAXON WILDE (33). The crowd, not entirely sure who he is, applauds politely as he says Hollywood is "running a nepo baby for President." On a cable news panel afterward, Simone Smilley (37), now a Republican commentator, is asked about it.

SIMONE (ON SCREEN)
Look, I'm a Republican. I'm at this convention. I support my party. But if your argument against my brother-in-law is Jaxon Wilde, you've already lost the argument.

VARIETY — FRI, JULY 19

Global CrowdStrike Outage Grounds Flights, Takes Down Hospitals and Banks

— SATURDAY, JULY 27. San Diego Comic-Con. Hall H. Six thousand fans. The lights go down. A figure in full, comic-accurate Kang the Conqueror armor walks onto the stage in total silence. He stops at center stage. Speaks one line in a voice electronically distorted beyond recognition, "I have conquered a thousand realities. Yours is next.", and walks off without taking off the helmet. No actor is announced. The hall loses its mind.

Twitter · #WhoIsKang

Trending #1 Worldwide · 3.8M Tweets

Twitter · @tyreseslayss_

it's been 197 days since tyrese posted. kang showed up at comic con with a voice changer and no actor credit. i'm not saying anything. i'm just saying ANYTHING.

41K Retweets · 288K Likes

Twitter · @tyreseslayss_'s replies

@MarvelHead99: "lmao Tyrese Avery is a POP STAR. there's zero chance. it's somebody like Idris or Mahershala or a total unknown."

92K Likes

AP — FRI, JULY 26

Paris Olympics Open With Rainy Ceremony on the Seine

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL — MON, AUG 5

Global Stocks Plunge as Recession Fears Grip Markets

THE ATLANTA JOURNAL-CONSTITUTION — THU, AUG 8

Georgia, Michigan, Pennsylvania Among 21 States to Ratify Proposed 28th Amendment; 17 More Needed

AXIOS — THU, AUG 8

Scoop: Bullock to announce running mate and full platform Friday in Los Angeles

POLITICO PLAYBOOK — FRI, AUG 9

The VP shortlist nobody can confirm: Shapiro? Whitmer? Moore? Warnock? Or the Vice President herself?

Bullock's camp has gone silent. Even top Democratic donors don't know.

ACT TWO — "THE TEXT"

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — CENTURY CITY — WAR ROOM — PRE-DAWN

SUPER: FRIDAY, AUGUST 9, 2024 — 5:58 AM PDT / 8:58 AM EDT

SUPER: 10 DAYS UNTIL THE DEMOCRATIC NATIONAL CONVENTION

The glass-walled corner office. Patti Grove (60), on her third coffee. Elxa (33), standing. Grace (30), at a laptop, finger hovering over a button labeled "SEND TO ALL." Arianna (31). Dante Reyes (43).

On the screen in front of Grace: a text message draft, ready to go to the campaign's list, eleven million cell phones.

INSERT — THE DRAFT TEXT: "It's official. Marc has chosen his running mate. Watch the announcement live at 9:30 AM PT from the street where it all started. Let's fix it. — Bullock for America"

GRACE
Eleven million phones. In sixty seconds.

PATTI
Obama did this in 2008. Text message VP announcement. Middle of the night. Biden. It leaked to the press first anyway, and it ruined it.

ELXA
Has ours leaked?

DANTE
No. Eleven people know. Six of them are in this room. Two of them are the candidate and the pick. One is the pick's wife. One is the candidate's wife. And one is a ten-year-old who has been sworn to secrecy and bribed with a second dog.

ARIANNA
Lyric knows?

DANTE
Lyric has known since July second. She has not told a single living soul. She's the most disciplined person on this campaign.

PATTI
Hire her.

GRACE
Six AM. Sending.

She clicks. A whoosh.

SUPER: 6:00:00 AM PDT — TEXT SENT TO 11.2 MILLION SUPPORTERS

Every phone in the room buzzes at once, because everyone in the room is on the list.

MONTAGE — PHONES BUZZING ACROSS AMERICA — 6:00 AM PDT / 9:00 AM EDT

— A coffee shop in Brooklyn. A dozen people look down at their phones at the same moment.

— A union hall in Macomb County. A guy in a UAW jacket reads it aloud: "From the street where it all started." Everybody turns to the guy next to him. "What street?"

— The Smilley parlor in Atlanta. Odessa (95) holding a flip phone at arm's length, squinting. Lorraine reads it over her shoulder.

ODESSA
"From the street where it all started." What street?

LORRAINE
Baldwin Hills, Mother Smilley. Where he grew up.

ODESSA
Next to Amond's mama.

A beat. Odessa lowers the phone very slowly. Looks at Lorraine.

ODESSA
...Oh, that boy is crazy.

— Houston. Roy Chapman (67), recliner, reading glasses. He reads the text. Turns to Tyler on the couch.

ROY
"The street where it all started." He's picking the Baker kid.

TYLER
Daddy, you don't know that.

ROY
I know men. He's picking his buddy.

TYLER
That's insane. They're both thirty-two. If the amendment fails —

ROY
Then he's betting the farm. I respect it. Stupid. But I respect it.

EXT. BALDWIN HILLS — THE STREET — MORNING

SUPER: 9:24 AM PDT / 12:24 PM EDT

The same street from the cold open, transformed. A small stage built on the lawn between the two houses, the white ranch with the red door and the two-story Spanish colonial. Bunting. American flags. A podium with a simple sign: "BULLOCK — BAKER."

Nobody outside the campaign has seen that sign until this moment. It's still covered with a navy cloth.

The street is packed. Three thousand people, mostly neighbors, families from Baldwin Hills, View Park, Leimert Park, Crenshaw. Grandmothers in lawn chairs. Kids on shoulders. A drumline from Dorsey High School. Every network's camera on a riser at the end of the block. Helicopters overhead. Secret Service snipers on the roofs of the neighboring houses, because this is what it is now.

On the porch of the white ranch house, in her Sunday best: Gloria Baker (58), dabbing her eyes with a tissue, flanked by Harmony (32), in yellow, and Lyric Baker (10), in a navy dress, holding the leash of BET the dog, who's wearing a tiny bow tie.

On the porch of the Spanish colonial next door, a woman in scrubs, MRS. ROSA DELGADO (61), a nurse at Kaiser Permanente who has owned the house since 2004, hosting the candidate's family on her lawn because Marc asked nicely and promised to replant her roses. Behind her: Natasha (53), Robert (55), Victor (78), Joan (76), and Esther (31), with Emma and Victoria (12).

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NEW YORK — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:27 PM EDT

David Muir (50), George Stephanopoulos (63).

DAVID MUIR
We're coming to you live from Los Angeles, where Marc-Anthony Bullock is minutes away from announcing his choice for Vice President. And we're getting our first clue, George. He's doing it on the street in Baldwin Hills where he grew up. Right in front of his childhood home. And, we're told, next door to the childhood home of his campaign co-chair, Amond Baker.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Which has everyone in Washington asking the same question: is he really going to do it? Amond Baker is thirty-two years old. Like Bullock, he's below the current constitutional age for the vice presidency, which by the Twelfth Amendment is the same as the presidency: thirty-five. If the 28th Amendment isn't ratified by thirty-eight states before January twentieth, and right now it's at twenty-one, a Bullock-Baker ticket couldn't take office even if it won. The Speaker of the House would act as President.

DAVID MUIR
So it would be the ultimate bet.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Given who we're talking about, David, I'd say that's on brand.

EXT. BALDWIN HILLS — THE STAGE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:30 AM PDT / 12:30 PM EDT

The Dorsey drumline kicks into a cadence. The crowd roars. Marc walks out of the front door of the Spanish colonial, his childhood home, in a navy suit, no tie. He walks across Mrs. Delgado's lawn, waves to her, mouths "Thank you," and steps up onto the stage.

The crowd chants "BET! BET! BET!" He lets it go. Then he raises a hand.

MARC
Good morning, Baldwin Hills!

ROAR.

MARC
I grew up in that house right there. Mrs. Delgado lives there now. She's a nurse at Kaiser. She's been one for thirty years. Give it up for Mrs. Delgado!

Huge cheer. Mrs. Delgado, mortified, waves.

MARC
I promised her I'd replant her roses. Mrs. Delgado, I'm a man of my word. Monday morning. Eight AM. I'll bring my own shovel.

(laughter)
And next door. In that house. With the red door. The basketball hoop with no net since 2006, because somebody, I'm not naming names, dunked on it when he was fourteen and tore the whole thing off.

Laughter. Gloria, on her porch, points directly at Marc and mouths "YOU." The crowd sees it and screams.

MARC
When I was four years old, my family moved onto this street. And on the first day, a little boy from the house with the red door walked across the lawn and tried to steal my Power Wheels. We fought over it. He won. I cried. His mama, Mrs. Gloria Baker, who taught fourth grade at LAUSD for thirty-one years and never once let either of us get away with anything, made him give it back and apologize.

(beat)
And he's been my brother every day since.

The crowd starts to understand. A rumble. A rising roar.

MARC
We grew up on this street. We broke a trampoline on this street. We played a Kid Mayor and his Deputy Mayor on the Nickelodeon soundstages, and then we came home to this street every night and did our homework at Mrs. Baker's kitchen table. When my daughters were born, he was the first person at the hospital. When his daughter was born, I was the second, because he'd already called his mama.

(laughter)
And for the last sixteen months, he's been the co-chair of this campaign. He's slept on the floor of a hotel suite in Detroit. He's handed me a trash can when I needed one. He's told me no when nobody else

would.

(beat)
Everybody told me to pick somebody safe. Somebody thirty-five. Somebody who could be President on January twentieth if the states don't ratify. Good people. Great people. Shapiro, Whitmer, Moore, Warnock, our wonderful Vice President. Any one of them would be extraordinary.

(beat)
But I started this campaign because a little girl asked me why age should matter if you're good at the job. And I'm not going to tell her, sixteen months later, that I didn't really mean it.

Marc turns toward the porch of the white ranch house. Toward Lyric.

MARC
Lyric. You kept a secret for thirty-eight days. You want to do the honors?

Lyric, ten years old, hands BET's leash to her grandmother, marches down the porch steps, across the lawn, and up onto the stage. The crowd SCREAMS. She walks to the covered sign on the podium. Grabs the navy cloth with both hands. Looks up at Marc.

MARC
Go ahead, Lyric-bird.

She pulls. The cloth falls.

INSERT — THE SIGN: "BULLOCK ✥ BAKER — LET'S FIX IT."

LYRIC
(into the microphone, at the top of her lungs)
MY DADDY'S THE VICE PRESIDENT!

The street EXPLODES. The drumline goes absolutely insane. People are screaming, hugging, crying. Grandmothers on their feet in lawn chairs. Kids jumping. The helicopters overhead seem to tilt.

MARC
(laughing, into the mic)
Running mate, baby! Running mate! He's not the Vice President YET!

LYRIC
(into the mic)
Same thing!

Marc doubles over laughing. And then he turns toward the white ranch house and points.

MARC
Ladies and gentlemen, the next Vice President of the United States, my brother, AMOND BAKER!

The red door of Gloria Baker's house swings open. Amond walks out onto his mother's porch in a navy suit. He hugs his mother. She holds his face in both hands and says something only he can hear. He kisses Harmony. He walks down his mother's front steps, across his mother's lawn, the same lawn where he stole a Power Wheels in 1996, and up onto the stage. He and Marc embrace. Lyric throws her arms around both of them at once.

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — PARLOR — ATLANTA — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 12:41 PM EDT

Odessa, Lorraine, Neil. And Cornelius (66), who turned sixty-six yesterday. The twins sent another cake; it's sitting half-eaten on the sideboard. He's in his chair at Odessa's left, arms crossed, watching.

NEIL
He did it. He actually did it.

CORNELIUS
He's insane.

ODESSA
He's loyal.

CORNELIUS
Mother, if those states don't ratify, Mike Johnson becomes President of the United States. Because Marc-Anthony Bullock wanted to pick his best friend.

ODESSA
And if they DO ratify?

Cornelius doesn't answer.

ODESSA
Then he picked a man who'd die for him. You tell me how many Presidents can say that about their Vice Presidents.

A long silence. Cornelius watches Amond hug his mother on the TV.

CORNELIUS
(quietly)
...Kennedy and Johnson hated each other.

ODESSA
That's right.

CORNELIUS
Lincoln and Johnson hated each other.

ODESSA
That's right.

CORNELIUS
Nixon couldn't stand Agnew.

ODESSA
Mm-hm.

Cornelius uncrosses his arms.

CORNELIUS
...It's still insane.

ODESSA
Baby, it's all insane. That boy announced at a birthday party. Insane is the brand.

EXT. BALDWIN HILLS — THE STAGE — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 9:47 AM PDT

Amond at the podium. The crowd quiets. He looks out at his neighbors. Pulls a folded piece of paper out of his jacket. Looks at it. Puts it back in his pocket.

AMOND
I wrote a speech. Harmony said it was good. Elxa said it was "fine." Patti said it was "too long." So I'm not going to read it.

(laughter)
I'm going to tell you one thing instead.

(beat)
Twenty-eight years ago I stole that man's Power Wheels. He's spent twenty-eight years getting even by making me famous, rich, and now possibly Vice President of the United States. It's the longest revenge in history.

(big laughter)
But here's the truth. My mama is standing on that porch. Thirty-one years teaching fourth grade in this city. She taught kids who didn't have shoes. Kids who didn't have breakfast. Kids whose parents were deported. Kids who slept in cars. She came home every night tired and she got up every morning and did it again. And she always said, "Amond, the job isn't to be important. The job is to be useful."

Gloria, on the porch, sobbing openly now.

AMOND
I'm thirty-two years old. I don't know everything. But I know how to be useful. And I know that man up here. He's the most useful person I've ever met. And if this country lets us, we're going to spend the next four years being as useful as two people can be.

(beat)
Mama. I'm not important. I'm useful. Just like you said.

The crowd erupts. On the porch, Gloria blows her son a kiss.

Twitter · #BullockBaker

Trending #1 Worldwide · 4.2M Tweets

Twitter · #DeputyMayor

Trending #3 in United States · 811K Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

THE KID MAYOR PICKED HIS DEPUTY MAYOR. LYRIC UNVEILED THE SIGN. "MY DADDY'S THE VICE PRESIDENT." "RUNNING MATE BABY." "SAME THING." I'M ON THE FLOOR OF MY OFFICE.

288K Retweets · 1.9M Likes · 9:44 AM PDT

TikTok · @kidmayormemes

[Side-by-side: 2006 Kid Mayor clip of 14-year-old Amond in a "DEPUTY MAYOR" sash saying "I've got your back, Mayor!" / today, Amond hugging Marc on stage] "18 YEARS LATER"

41.8M views · 9.2M likes

Twitter · @NumbersNerdPol

Average age of the Democratic ticket: 32. Average age of the Republican ticket: 59. Difference: 27 years. Largest generational gap between two tickets in American history.

18K Retweets · 92K Likes

Twitter · @GOPstrategist_DC

Two 32-year-old former child actors on a national ticket, neither of whom is constitutionally eligible to serve today. This is not a campaign. It's a sitcom pitch.

22K Retweets · 81K Likes

Twitter · @GOPstrategist_DC's replies

@RoyChapmanHouston: "And it's winning."

141K Likes

Twitter · @gloriabaker.teaches (new account, 12 followers)

My son. My baby. "The job is to be useful." I said that in 1999 when he wouldn't do his homework. Lord.

312K Retweets · 2.4M Likes

ACT THREE — "CULTURE'S BIGGEST NIGHT"

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — CENTURY CITY — AFTERNOON

SUPER: FRIDAY, AUGUST 9, 2024 — 1:15 PM PDT

The bullpen. Three hundred staffers, still buzzing. On the big screens: every network running the announcement on a loop. On one screen, CNN shows a split image: the Bullock-Baker stage on the left, and on the right a graphic headlined "THE DNC: 'NOT YOUR TYPICAL CONVENTION'?"

In the war room, Grace (30) bursts in holding her phone over her head like a torch.

GRACE
Variety. Just dropped. They got it.

PATTI
Got what?

GRACE
The convention.

Everyone turns. Grace reads.

GRACE
"EXCLUSIVE: Democratic Convention to Be Staged Like an Awards Show. Sources say next week's DNC in Chicago will abandon the traditional parade of politicians in favor of a tightly produced, star-studded, four-night spectacle modeled on, quote, 'the BET Awards, the Oscars, and the Super Bowl halftime show, at the same time.' One person involved in the planning called it 'Culture's Biggest Night.'"

ELXA
Who's the source?

GRACE
It says "a person familiar with the planning."

ELXA
Grace.

GRACE
It wasn't me!

ARIANNA
It was definitely you.

GRACE
I said "Culture's Biggest Night" ONE TIME in a group chat with three producers —

PATTI
Grace, honey, there's no such thing as a group chat with three producers. There's just a press release with extra steps.

Grace keeps reading.

GRACE
"The convention's volunteer creative director is said to be Oscar-nominated filmmaker Robert Bullock, the candidate's father, working unpaid, a structure campaign-finance lawyers say is permitted under federal rules governing volunteer services. Donohue Entertainment, the candidate's family's company, is not involved in any capacity, according to the DNC."

ARIANNA
(nodding)
That's right. Robert's a volunteer. Personal time. No Donohue resources, no Donohue staff, no Donohue cameras. I wrote the memo myself. Natasha signed it. She's not allowed in the building until Thursday night.

ELXA
Mama is going to hate that.

ARIANNA
Your mother read it twice and said, quote, "Fine. I'll buy a ticket."

GRACE
(still reading)
"Rumored elements include a live band throughout, musical performances every night, celebrity hosts instead of traditional chairs, a comedy segment, and an in memoriam tribute. Speculation is mounting that pop superstar Tyrese Avery, who has not been seen publicly in seven months, will end his 'creative sabbatical' with a performance."

A beat. Everyone looks at Grace.

GRACE
I did NOT say that.

ELXA
Is it true?

GRACE
I don't KNOW. Marc won't tell me ANYTHING about Tyrese. Every time I ask he says "sabbatical" and walks away.

VARIETY — 1:04 PM PDT

EXCLUSIVE: Democratic Convention to Be Staged Like an Awards Show — 'Culture's Biggest Night'

Robert Bullock to serve as volunteer creative director; four nights of performances, celebrity hosts, and a live band; Donohue "not involved."

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Hollywood Braces for the Most Star-Studded Political Convention Ever — and Every Publicist in Town Is Calling Chicago

DEADLINE

'It's Not a Convention, It's a Cookout': Inside the DNC's Plan to Turn the United Center Into the Biggest Show of the Year

POLITICO

Democrats' 'awards show' convention thrills young voters, unnerves party elders: 'Where do the senators go?'

FOX NEWS

Democrats Turn Convention Into Hollywood Party as Nation Faces Real Problems

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

THE DNC IS GOING TO BE THE BET AWARDS. ROBERT BULLOCK IS DIRECTING. A LIVE BAND. AN IN MEMORIAM. TYRESE MIGHT COME BACK. THIS IS NOT A CONVENTION, IT IS A CULTURAL RESET.

202K Retweets · 1.4M Likes

Twitter · @tyreseslayss_

IF TYRESE COMES BACK AT THE DNC I WILL REGISTER AS A DEMOCRAT AND I'M CANADIAN

61K Retweets · 410K Likes

Twitter · @DNCwatcher

Traditional DNC night: 14 speeches from governors you've never heard of, a balloon drop, and a guy from Delaware's Democratic Party saying "Delaware casts its votes." Bullock's DNC night: apparently a full concert. I'm not mad.

31K Retweets · 177K Likes

Twitter · @SenatorStaffer_anon

My boss, a sitting U.S. senator, just asked me whether he's "a performer or an audience member" at next week's convention. I didn't know how to answer.

88K Retweets · 701K Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

As a Republican I'm contractually obligated to be against the Democratic convention. As a Smilley I've been to Robert Bullock's movie premieres. I'm going to be watching all four nights with snacks and I'm not apologizing.

41K Retweets · 302K Likes

ACT FOUR — "THE FIX"

EXT. LOS ANGELES MEMORIAL COLISEUM — EXPOSITION PARK — EVENING

SUPER: FRIDAY, AUGUST 9, 2024 — 5:52 PM PDT / 8:52 PM EDT

The Coliseum: built in 1923, the same year as Donohue and Greater Mount Calvary. Host of two Olympics, two Super Bowls, a papal Mass, and Martin Luther King Jr. And in four years, it will host its third Olympics. This Sunday, in Paris, the Olympic flag will be handed to Los Angeles.

Tonight, the peristyle end is draped with a massive navy banner: "THE FIX — THE BULLOCK-BAKER PLAN FOR AMERICA." A stage at the fifty-yard line. Every seat is full, seventy-seven thousand of them, with thousands more outside on Figueroa Street watching on giant screens. The Olympic cauldron atop the peristyle is lit for the first time since a USC home game.

In a VIP section near the stage: Esther (31), the twins (12), Lyric (10), Harmony (32), Gloria Baker (58), Natasha (53), Robert (55), Victor (78), Joan (76). Elxa, Grace, Patti, and Arianna in a production booth. Tyler (32) and ROY CHAPMAN (67), the latter in a "REPUBLICANS FOR BULLOCK" cap, looking deeply uncomfortable and also, secretly, thrilled. Tayia (32) is the emcee.

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NEW YORK — CONTINUOUS

SUPER: 8:58 PM EDT

DAVID MUIR
Welcome back. A big day in this race just got bigger. This morning Marc-Anthony Bullock named his running mate, thirty-two-year-old Amond Baker. Tonight, at the Los Angeles Coliseum, in front of seventy-seven thousand people, the Bullock-Baker ticket unveils the full platform it will take to the convention in Chicago. The campaign calls it "The Fix."

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
We've been told to expect, and I'm quoting a senior campaign official, "the most ambitious platform in the history of either party." We'll see.

EXT. LOS ANGELES MEMORIAL COLISEUM — THE STAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 6:04 PM PDT / 9:04 PM EDT

Tayia introduces Amond. Amond introduces Marc. "Ain't No Mountain High Enough." Seventy-seven thousand people on their feet. Marc walks to center stage, alone, no podium, a wireless mic in his hand. The stage lights go down until there's just one spotlight.

MARC
Los Angeles.

The Coliseum ROARS.

MARC
Sixteen months ago, at a birthday party, I said I'd run for President. I didn't have a plan. I didn't have a platform. I had vibes. My sister wrote that on a whiteboard. "Assets: Vibes."

(laughter)
Tonight I'm going to tell you the plan.

(beat)
And I want to warn you up front. Some of it is going to sound impossible. Some of it is going to make economists faint. Some of it is going to make my Republican friend Roy Chapman, who is sitting right there in a Republicans for Bullock hat, very uncomfortable.

A camera finds Roy. He gives a tiny, deeply reluctant wave. The crowd cheers wildly.

MARC
But every single thing I'm about to say, people told me was impossible about something else. A thirty-one-year-old couldn't run. He did. He couldn't win a primary against a sitting President. He did. Congress would never pass an amendment for him. They did.

(beat)
So here's "The Fix." Eleven things. One big dream. Let's go.

Behind him, a massive screen lights up: "1. HEALTHCARE FOR EVERY AMERICAN."

MARC
One. Universal healthcare. Every American. Covered. Day one of your life to the last. If you like your private insurance, keep it. If you don't have any, you're covered. If you lose your job, you're covered. No American will ever go bankrupt because they got sick. Ever.

A roar.

"2. EDUCATION FOR EVERY AMERICAN."

MARC
Two. Universal education. Pre-K through college or trade school. Tuition-free. Every teacher paid like the most important person in their community, because they are. Ask Mrs. Gloria Baker. Thirty-one years.

The camera finds Gloria, who covers her face. The crowd goes wild.

"3. ELIMINATE THE NATIONAL DEBT."

MARC
Three. The national debt is thirty-five trillion dollars. My plan is to pay off every single cent of it.

A beat of stunned silence. Then a strange sound from seventy-seven thousand people: half cheer, half disbelieving laugh.

MARC
I know. I KNOW. Every economist watching just spit out their wine. Here's how: we stop running this country like a credit card and start running it like a family business. We create the American Sovereign Fund, a national investment fund seeded by the assets this country already owns and has never invested: federal land and mineral rights, the airwaves, the patents that came out of government research. The internet started as a government project. Norway built a fund like this out of oil. We're going to build ours out of everything. Every dollar it earns pays down the debt. Then it pays you.

Applause. Not universal. But big.

"4. PEACE IN THE WORLD."

MARC
Four. World peace.

(beat)
I know how that sounds. Like a Miss America answer. Lorraine Smilley competed in Miss Black America, and she told me she said "world peace" in 1981 and lost.

(laughter)
But I'm serious. Within the first hundred days, I will personally convene peace talks. Ukraine and Russia. Israel and the Palestinians, with every hostage home and every civilian protected. The Taiwan Strait. I'll sit at the table myself. As long as it takes. Every life counts the same.

A long, building applause.

"5. PEACE AT HOME."

MARC
Five. Peace at home. A month ago, a man was shot at for running for President. A firefighter died protecting his family. That can never happen in this country again. Not to Donald Trump. Not to me. Not to anybody. We're going to turn the temperature down. Police and communities. Neighbors and neighbors. Democrats and Republicans. We're going to remember how to disagree without wanting each other dead.

Quieter applause. Respectful. In the VIP section, Roy Chapman nods slowly.

"6. END INFLATION." "7. MAKE IT AFFORDABLE."

MARC
Six and seven go together. End inflation, and make everything affordable again. Groceries. Gas. Rent. Childcare. Insulin. We'll build ten million homes in four years, because the reason rent is crazy is that there aren't enough places to live. We'll cap insulin and every life-saving drug. We'll make childcare free for every working family. When things are affordable, people can breathe. I want this whole country to be able to breathe.

"8. AMERICA, THE SUPERPOWER."

MARC
Eight. I want the United States to be the undisputed superpower of the twenty-first century. Strongest military. Strongest economy. Strongest technology. We build the chips here. We build the AI here. We build the cars here, union-made, in Michigan and Ohio. Nobody pushes America around. And nobody needs to, because we'll be the country everybody wants to be friends with.

A huge roar. Roy Chapman is clapping.

"9. LOWER TAXES. THEN NO TAXES."

MARC
Nine.

(he grins)
Roy, this one's for you. Lower taxes. A lot lower. And eventually, for working families, zero federal income tax.

A beat of shock. Then the Coliseum EXPLODES. In the VIP section, Roy Chapman is on his feet, both arms in the air. Tyler is staring at his father in horror and delight.

MARC

I know. A Democrat said it. Here's how: the American Sovereign Fund. As it grows, it replaces income taxes. First for families making under a hundred thousand dollars. Then two hundred. Then everybody. There are better ways for a country to make money than taking it out of your paycheck. Norway knows it. Alaska sends people a check every year just for living there. We're going to do it bigger.

"10. CLEAN AMERICA."

MARC

Ten. Make this country one hundred percent clean. Clean energy. Clean air. Clean water. Every lead pipe in Flint and every other town, gone, in four years. And clean government. Members of Congress banned from trading stocks. Lobbyists banned from writing laws. Super PACs, gone. If you want to buy a politician, you'll have to go to a different country.

Bipartisan roar. The stock-trading ban is one of the most popular ideas in America.

The screen goes dark. One word appears: "11."

Marc walks to the edge of the stage. The crowd gets quieter. They can feel it coming.

MARC

Eleven.

(beat)

My wife's grandmother is ninety-five years old. Her grandparents were sharecroppers in Albany, Georgia. My great-great-grandfather couldn't buy land in Burbank in his own name. Amond's mama taught kids whose parents were deported in the middle of the school year. This whole country was built by people who came here. Some came in chains. Some came on boats. Some walked across a desert. And every single one of them made America what it is.

(beat)

Here's eleven. If you want to come to the United States of America, to work, to build, to raise your family, to become an American, you can. Legally. All of you. Registered. Vetted. Welcomed. Number eleven is one hundred percent legal immigration. Open the door all the way, and make every person who walks through it legal on day one.

(beat)
There will be no more "illegal immigration" in the United States, because there will be no such thing as an illegal immigrant. There will just be immigrants. And then there will be Americans.

A moment of total silence in the Coliseum.

And then the sound. Not a cheer. A wall. Seventy-seven thousand people, many of them immigrants or the children of immigrants in a city where nearly four in ten residents were born in another country, coming to their feet with a noise that shakes the peristyle. Grown men sobbing. Abuelas in the upper deck waving flags of Mexico, El Salvador, Guatemala, the Philippines, Korea, Armenia, Nigeria, Ethiopia, Iran, all next to American ones.

In the VIP section, Roy Chapman is NOT on his feet. He's sitting very still, arms crossed, frowning. Tyler watches him nervously.

Marc waits for the noise to fall. It takes almost two minutes.

MARC
And now the dream.

The screen behind him: a map of North America. The United States, Canada, and Mexico, with no borders drawn between them. One word across it:

"UNION."

MARC
The European Union took a continent that fought two world wars against itself and made it a place where you can drive from Paris to Berlin without showing a passport. We can do better than that. We're already neighbors. We already trade more with each other than almost anybody on Earth. Canada. Mexico. The United States.

(beat)
In my first term, I will begin negotiations with the governments of Canada and Mexico on a North American Union: an economic and political partnership of free people, free trade, free movement, and a shared future. It won't happen overnight. It might take a decade. But someday my granddaughters are going to drive from Toronto to Mexico City and not even think about it.

(beat, a small smile)
And yes. I know. The internet's been saying the "North American Union" was a conspiracy theory since 2006. Surprise. It's not a conspiracy. It's a campaign promise.

Laughter, cheering, and in some corners of the stadium, shock.

MARC
That's the Fix. Eleven things. One dream. Some of you love all of it. Some of you love half of it and think I'm crazy about the other half. Good. That means you were listening.

(beat)
Ten days from now, in Chicago, we take this to the convention. In eighty-eight days, we take it to the country.

(beat)
They say it's impossible.

He raises the mic.

CROWD
(seventy-seven thousand)
BET!

Fireworks over the peristyle. The cauldron flares. Amond, Esther, the twins, Lyric, Harmony, Gloria rush the stage. Confetti fills the air above the fifty-yard line.

SUPER: 6:51 PM PDT — "THE FIX" UNVEILED — 77,000 IN THE COLISEUM, AN ESTIMATED 52 MILLION WATCHING

ACT FIVE — "PANDEMONIUM"

INT. ABC NEWS — SPECIAL COVERAGE — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:58 PM EDT

Muir and George, joined by the Political Director, DR. MALCOLM REESE (55), and REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE (61). Every one of them looks a little stunned.

DAVID MUIR
Well. That happened.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Universal healthcare. Universal education. Eliminating the national debt. World peace. Zero federal income tax for working families. One hundred percent legal immigration. And a North American Union with Canada and Mexico. I've covered politics for thirty years. I've never seen anything like it from a major-party nominee.

DAVID MUIR
Congresswoman Kastle.

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
David, I'm a Republican, and I'm going to be honest. Half of that speech, my party would love. Zero income tax. A Congressional stock-trading ban. Strongest military on Earth. "Run the country like a family business." He stole about six of our lines. And he did it better.

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
And the other half?

REP. (RET.) DIANE KASTLE
The other half is going to be the entire Republican campaign from now until November. "Open borders." "North American Union." "Eliminate the debt." Every Republican ad for the next eighty-eight days writes itself. "He wants to erase the border with Mexico." "He believes in a conspiracy theory." And millions of Americans will believe it, because some of it is right there in the speech.

DR. MALCOLM REESE
David, if I may. The coalition he's building is unlike anything in modern history. That immigration section: did you see that stadium? In a city where four in ten people were born abroad. Latino voters, Asian-American voters, African immigrants. Nobody has ever spoken to them like that from a national stage. And the tax plan just handed him a reason for every working-class Republican to take a second look.

DAVID MUIR
But can any of it actually happen?

The Political Director pulls up a graphic: "THE FIX: REALITY CHECK."

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
Short version? Some of it, with a big enough Congress. The stock-trading ban has broad support in both parties. Healthcare and education could advance through budget reconciliation with fifty-one votes. Immigration requires rewriting the Immigration and Nationality Act, which means sixty votes in the Senate, or eliminating the filibuster. The North American Union would require either a treaty, sixty-seven senators, or legislation through both chambers, plus agreement from two other sovereign nations. And eliminating thirty-five trillion dollars in debt...

GEORGE STEPHANOPOULOS
Every economist we called tonight said some version of "impossible."

ABC POLITICAL DIRECTOR
And he said some version of "bet."

DAVID MUIR
Which, in fairness, has worked so far.

MONTAGE — REACTIONS — FRIDAY NIGHT INTO SATURDAY, AUGUST 9–10, 2024

— 10:14 PM EDT. A statement from the Trump campaign, issued by a spokesperson, calling the platform "the most radical agenda in American history: open borders, a socialist takeover of health

care, and a plan to erase America's border with Mexico," and saying the Bullock-Baker ticket is "two Hollywood kids who can't legally serve."

— 10:41 PM EDT. Senator JD Vance (40), Trump's running mate, posts that the North American Union is the kind of idea elites have pushed for decades, and mocks the Bullock-Baker ticket as a buddy comedy.

— 11:20 PM EDT. In Mexico City, a spokesperson for President Andrés Manuel López Obrador, whose term ends October 1, says Mexico welcomes proposals of friendship and cooperation among North American peoples, and declines further comment. Aides to President-elect Claudia Sheinbaum say she will study the proposal.

— 11:52 PM EDT. In Ottawa, the Prime Minister's Office issues a careful statement stressing Canadian sovereignty, the depth of the U.S. partnership, and its readiness to work with whoever Americans elect.

— SATURDAY, 7:00 AM EDT. Fox News, morning programming: a split screen of Marc on stage and a map of the U.S.–Mexico border with the line erased. Chyron: "BULLOCK: ERASE THE BORDER."

— SATURDAY, 8:30 AM EDT. CNN: a panel of economists. One calls the American Sovereign Fund "creative but fantastical." Another, a former Treasury official, says it is "the first genuinely new idea in fiscal policy in my lifetime, and I don't know if it's brilliant or insane." A third says simply, "Thirty-five trillion dollars. No."

— SATURDAY, 9:15 AM PDT. A Home Depot parking lot in East Los Angeles. A group of day laborers watching the speech clip on one man's phone, the "eleven" section. One of them, an older man from Michoacán, crosses himself.

Twitter · #TheFix

Trending #1 Worldwide · 6.7M Tweets

Twitter · #NorthAmericanUnion

Trending #2 Worldwide · 3.1M Tweets

Twitter · #ZeroIncomeTax

Trending #3 in United States · 2.2M Tweets

Twitter · #OpenBorders

Trending #4 in United States · 1.9M Tweets

Twitter · @TheBullpenDaily

UNIVERSAL HEALTHCARE. FREE COLLEGE. ZERO INCOME TAX. WORLD PEACE. PAY OFF THE DEBT. EVERY IMMIGRANT LEGAL. AND A NORTH AMERICAN UNION. I'VE NEVER SCREAMED THIS LOUD AT A PLATFORM BEFORE. I DIDN'T KNOW YOU COULD SCREAM AT A PLATFORM.

401K Retweets · 2.8M Likes

Twitter · @NAUtruther2006

I've been saying the North American Union was real since 2006 and everyone called me crazy. I was right. I still hate it. But I was right.

211K Retweets · 1.4M Likes

Twitter · @NAUtruther2006's replies

@KidMayorStan: "sir you're going viral for being right about the thing you hate. congratulations?"

88K Likes

Twitter · @TexasRancher_88

Zero income tax. A Democrat. I'm going to need to lie down.

62K Retweets · 401K Likes

Twitter · @TexasRancher_88's replies

@BorderHawk_AZ: "and every illegal gets to stay. enjoy your zero taxes when 20 million more people come across."

31K Likes

Twitter · @TexasRancher_88's replies

@TexasRancher_88: "@BorderHawk_AZ yeah that part I don't like. Still thinking."

44K Likes

Twitter · @HarvardEcon_Prof

I've been asked 40 times today whether the "American Sovereign Fund" can pay off $35T in debt. Honest answer: not in four years, not in eight. In 30 years, with huge returns and discipline? It's no longer laughable. That's the most I've ever said about a campaign promise.

18K Retweets · 92K Likes

TikTok · @abuela.y.yo.la

[Video: an elderly Salvadoran woman in the Coliseum's upper deck, sobbing, waving an American flag and a Salvadoran flag at the same time during "Number eleven"] "36 years undocumented. my abuela heard a man running for president say she can be legal. i've never seen her cry like this."

38.4M views · 11.2M likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl

A North American Union would require surrendering American sovereignty. This is the most dangerous platform in the history of the Republic, delivered by a man who STILL can't constitutionally serve. 21 states. Not 38.

14K Retweets · 61K Likes

Twitter · @ConstitutionCarl's replies

@ArizonaGrandpa: "Carl, Mexico said they'd study it. Canada said they'd work with whoever wins. Nobody's surrendering anything. Relax and have a burrito."

92K Likes

Twitter · @jaxonwilde

Open borders, world peace, and free everything. The Kid Mayor finally told you his real platform. Episode 61 of Wilde Card is up.

6,108 Retweets · 22K Likes

Twitter · @TayiaBoyd

@jaxonwilde Jaxon, you spoke at the RNC in a cowboy hat. You don't get to call anybody else's platform a costume.

288K Retweets · 2.1M Likes

Twitter · @SimoneSmilley

Honest Republican review of "The Fix": Taxes, 10/10, I'm stealing it. Stock ban, 10/10. Military, 9/10. Border, 2/10, absolutely not. North American Union, I need to sit with my grandmother and a glass of sweet tea. Overall: I hate how good of a speech it was.

102K Retweets · 891K Likes

Twitter · @RoyChapmanHouston

Zero income tax: yes. Strongest military: yes. Stock ban: yes. Every immigrant legal: I'm going to have to talk to the boy about that one. Don't make it a whole thing.

501K Retweets · 3.8M Likes

Reddit · r/politics

"MEGATHREAD: Bullock unveils 'The Fix': universal healthcare and education, debt elimination, zero income tax for working families, 100% legal immigration, and a North American Union"

521K upvotes · 102,811 comments · Top comment: "Republicans: 'He stole our tax plan.' Democrats: 'He stole our healthcare plan.' Libertarians: 'He stole our sovereign wealth fund.' Conspiracy theorists: 'He stole our conspiracy theory.' The man is a kleptomaniac of popular ideas."

Reddit · r/neoliberal

"The American Sovereign Fund is either the dumbest or smartest fiscal idea of the century and I genuinely cannot tell which"

41K upvotes

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Bullock picks childhood friend Amond Baker, 32, as running mate, then unveils sweeping agenda including 100% legal immigration and a 'North American Union'

THE NEW YORK TIMES

Bullock's Breathtaking Platform: Universal Health Care, Zero Income Tax, Open Immigration, and a Continental Union

Economists call the debt-elimination pledge unrealistic; Republicans see an opening on the border; Democrats see a coalition no one has assembled before.

THE WASHINGTON POST

With Baker Pick, Bullock Goes All In on the Age Amendment, and the House

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

Markets Weigh Bullock's 'American Sovereign Fund'; Treasury Yields Edge Lower on Debt Pledge, Then Rebound

POLITICO

'He stole six of our lines': Republicans privately admit Bullock's tax message lands, publicly hammer the border

AXIOS

The Fix, by the numbers: 11 promises, 1 union, 3 countries, $35 trillion

FIVETHIRTYEIGHT

Instant reaction polling: The Fix is popular, except for the parts that aren't

FOX NEWS

Bullock-Baker Unveil 'Open Borders' Agenda, Vow to Erase U.S.-Mexico Border in 'North American Union'

LA OPINIÓN

"Number Eleven": Bullock Promete Legalidad Total Para Todos los Inmigrantes; Lágrimas en el Coliseo

THE GLOBE AND MAIL (CANADA)

U.S. Democratic Nominee Proposes 'North American Union'; Ottawa Responds Cautiously

EL UNIVERSAL (MÉXICO)

Bullock Propone Unión de América del Norte; el Equipo de Sheinbaum Dice que Estudiará la Propuesta

VARIETY

Bullock's Coliseum Rally Draws Estimated 52 Million Across Platforms, Rivaling Oscars Viewership

THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER

Kid Mayor and Deputy Mayor: How Two Bluebird Kids Became the Democratic Ticket

PEOPLE

Lyric Baker, 10, Unveils Her Dad as Running Mate: 'My Daddy's the Vice President!'

DEADLINE

'Kid Mayor' Season 1 Finale Hits No. 1 on Donohue+ — Two Days Before Convention Prep Begins

MONTAGE — INSTANT POLLS — SATURDAY, AUGUST 10, 2024

A series of poll graphics, one after another.

GRAPHIC — "BULLOCK-BAKER VS. TRUMP-VANCE (NATIONAL, POST-FIX): BULLOCK 53% · TRUMP 43%"

GRAPHIC — "SUPPORT FOR SPECIFIC PROPOSALS: Congressional stock-trading ban 84% · Universal healthcare 67% · Tuition-free

college/trade school 63% · Zero income tax for families under $100K 71% · 100% legal immigration 46% support / 49% oppose · North American Union 34% support / 51% oppose · Eliminate the national debt 'seems realistic' 22%"

GRAPHIC — "RATIFICATION OF 28TH AMENDMENT: 21 STATES RATIFIED · 17 NEEDED · DEADLINE FOR INAUGURATION: JAN 20, 2025"

INT. BULLOCK FOR AMERICA HQ — WAR ROOM — LATE NIGHT

SUPER: FRIDAY, AUGUST 9, 2024 — 11:48 PM PDT

Patti alone, finally sitting down, with a bottle of bourbon and two glasses. Elxa enters. Patti pours the second glass without asking.

PATTI
Number eleven costs us Arizona.

ELXA
Maybe.

PATTI
Maybe Georgia. Maybe Pennsylvania. The NAU costs us Wisconsin. Fox runs "ERASE THE BORDER" for eighty-eight days straight.

ELXA
And?

PATTI
And the zero income tax wins us Ohio. The healthcare wins us Michigan. The Latino turnout wins us Nevada and maybe Texas. And the stock ban wins us everybody who's ever hated Congress, which is everybody.

ELXA
So it's a wash?

PATTI
It's not a wash. It's a rollercoaster. And your brother just built it, got on, and threw away the safety bar.

They drink.

ELXA
You could've talked him out of eleven.

PATTI
I tried. For three weeks. You know what he said?

ELXA
What?

PATTI
He said, "Patti, Amond's mama taught kids whose parents got deported in the middle of the school year. She told me about one little boy who came to school the next morning anyway, sat at his desk, and finished his spelling test. Then he went home to an empty apartment."

(beat)
Then he said, "I'm not running for President to be careful about that boy."

Elxa looks into her glass.

ELXA
...That's very him.

PATTI
Everything's very him. That's the problem. And it's the whole campaign.

TAG

INT. SMILLEY HOUSE — CORNELIUS'S STUDY — ATLANTA — NIGHT

SUPER: SATURDAY, AUGUST 10, 2024 — 12:31 AM EDT

Cornelius (66) at his desk. One lamp. The TV on mute, showing the end of the Coliseum speech on a loop. On the desk: a legal pad covered in his handwriting. Not the Bullock File. A new pad. At the top, underlined: "THE FIX — PROBLEMS."

Under it, a list:

INSERT — LEGAL PAD: "1. Debt — $35T. Fund math fails. Give a real number. 2. #11 — 'Open the door all the way' = Fox's ad for 88 days. Say 'ORDERLY.' Say 'SECURE.' Say 'LEGAL' five times. 3. NAU — too soon. Say 'partnership.' Never say 'union' in Georgia. 4. Zero tax — brilliant. Lead with it. 5. Stock ban — lead with it. 6. Baker — reckless. Correct. (?)"

He looks at the question mark next to "correct." Taps his pen on it. Then he picks up his phone.

Scrolls to "MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK." Presses call.

One ring. Two.

MARC (V.O.)
(groggy, surprised)
...Hello?

CORNELIUS
It's Cornelius.

A long silence. On the other end, in Los Angeles, Marc sits up in bed.

INTERCUT — INT. SUNRISE HILL — MASTER BEDROOM — NIGHT

SUPER: 9:32 PM PDT

Marc, in a t-shirt, sitting up in bed. Esther beside him, awake now, watching his face.

MARC
...Hi, Dad.

CORNELIUS
I watched the speech.

MARC
Yeah?

CORNELIUS
Number eleven is going to cost you Arizona if you keep saying "open the door all the way." Say "orderly." Say "secure." Say "legal" five times in every sentence. The country isn't afraid of immigrants, son. It's afraid of chaos. Give them order, and they'll give you the door.

Marc blinks. Esther's hand goes to her mouth.

MARC
...Okay.

CORNELIUS
And never, ever say "union" in Georgia. Say "partnership." White voters in Cobb County hear "union" and think of the Teamsters. Black voters in Albany hear "union" and think of the Civil War. Nobody hears "European Union." Say partnership.

MARC
Partnership. Okay.

CORNELIUS
The debt number's a fantasy. Everybody knows it. Don't promise to eliminate it in a term. Promise to put it on a path. Give them a date thirty years from now and a fund that's real. People forgive ambition. They don't forgive arithmetic.

MARC
"People forgive ambition. They don't forgive arithmetic." Can I steal that?

CORNELIUS
You've been stealing my daughter for twenty years. Take the line.

Esther laughs out loud, and has to cover her mouth. On the other end, a pause.

CORNELIUS
Is she laughing?

MARC
She's laughing.

CORNELIUS
...Good.

A long silence. Cornelius looks at the last item on his list. "Baker — reckless. Correct. (?)"

CORNELIUS
And the Baker boy.

MARC
Yeah?

Cornelius picks up his pen. Crosses out the question mark.

CORNELIUS
It was reckless. It was the most reckless vice-presidential pick since 1972. If those states don't ratify, you'll have handed the country to a Speaker nobody elected.

MARC
I know.

CORNELIUS
And it was right.

Marc freezes.

CORNELIUS
Kennedy and Johnson hated each other. Lincoln and Johnson hated each other. Your Vice President would take a bullet for you. My mother made me say that out loud this morning. She was right too.

(beat)
Don't tell her I said that.

MARC
I won't.

CORNELIUS
You will. You tell her everything. She calls you "my grandson-in-law" now. To the pastor.

Marc laughs. Quietly. Wipes his eyes.

CORNELIUS
I'll be in Chicago. With the Georgia delegation. Neil got me a seat. Your mother-in-law insisted. My mother insisted harder.

MARC
I'll be glad to see you there.

CORNELIUS
I'm not campaigning for you.

MARC
I know.

CORNELIUS
I'm going because my granddaughters will be there. And because the Georgia roll call should be cast by a Smilley. It has been since 1972.

MARC
...Which Smilley?

A long, long pause.

CORNELIUS
We'll see.

Marc grins. Esther, beside him, has tears running down her face.

CORNELIUS
Go to sleep. You've got a convention in ten days and you sound like a man who stood in a stadium for an hour.

MARC
Goodnight, Dad.

Another pause. Cornelius looks at the legal pad. At the photograph of Thaddeus and Joan on the corner of the desk. At the twins' card, framed now, beside it.

CORNELIUS
...Goodnight, son.

Click.

In Los Angeles, Marc stares at the phone in his hand. Then he turns to Esther. She's already reaching for him.

ESTHER
Did he just —

MARC
He called me "son."

In Atlanta, Cornelius sets the phone down. Looks at the list one more time. Tears the page off the legal pad, folds it into thirds, and puts it in an envelope. Writes on the front: "FOR MARC —

CHICAGO."

He turns off the lamp.

SMASH TO BLACK.

SUPER: DEMOCRATIC NATIONAL CONVENTION — UNITED CENTER, CHICAGO — MONDAY, AUGUST 19, 2024 — 9 DAYS

SUPER: END OF CHAPTER EIGHT

CONTINUITY LEDGER — CHAPTER 8

Timeline: Mon Jul 1, 2024, 11:52 PM PDT (cold open) → montage (Apr 26–Aug 8) → **Fri Aug 9, 2024: VP announcement 9:30 AM PDT in Baldwin Hills; "The Fix" platform at the LA Memorial Coliseum 6:04–6:51 PM PDT** → Sat Aug 10, 12:31 AM EDT / Fri Aug 9, 9:32 PM PDT (Cornelius's call). DNC: United Center, Chicago, Mon–Thu, Aug 19–22, 2024.

Ages (Aug 9, 2024): Marc 32 · Amond 32 · Esther 31 · Harmony 32 · Emma & Victoria 12 (turned 12 May 10) · Lyric 10 · Tyrese 33 · Arianna 31 · Tyler 32 · Tayia 32 · Elxa 33 · Grace 30 · Natasha 53 · Robert 55 · Victor 78 · Joan 76 · Odessa 95 · **Cornelius 66 (turned 66 Thu Aug 8)** · Lorraine 62 · Neil 40 · Simone 37 · Patti 60 · Dante 43 · Roy Chapman 67 · Gloria Baker 58 (fictional, b. Mar 3, 1966) · Rosa Delgado 61 (fictional) · Jaxon Wilde 33. Real people: Trump 78 · JD Vance 40 · Biden 81 · Harris 59 · Clyburn 83 (at the May meeting) · Muir 50 · Stephanopoulos 63.

Real events depicted: Trump convicted on 34 counts (May 30); SCOTUS immunity ruling Trump v. United States (Jul 1); Butler, PA assassination attempt (Sat Jul 13, ~6:11 PM EDT), with Trump wounded, Corey Comperatore killed, two others critically wounded, and the gunman killed; RNC in Milwaukee (Jul 15–18); Vance picked (Jul 15); CrowdStrike outage (Jul 19); Paris Olympics open (Jul 26) and close with the LA handoff (Sun Aug 11); global market selloff (Aug 5); AMLO's term ends Oct 1, 2024; President-elect Claudia Sheinbaum; Alaska Permanent Fund and Norway's sovereign fund as precedents; Obama's 2008 text-message VP announcement; national debt about $35T; the 1923 LA Coliseum (1932 and 1984 Olympics, 2028 to come; Dr. King spoke there in 1964).

Our-world events: 28th Amendment passes Congress Mon Jul 1, 2024: House 297–134, Senate 67–32 (one to spare; the last vote from an unnamed Mountain West senator "whose granddaughter told him to"), with 41 House Republicans in the coalition. 21 states ratified by Aug 8 (including GA, MI, PA); 17 more needed. **Marc asks Amond on the Baldwin Hills curb, Jul 1, 11:52 PM PDT**, where "M.A.B. + A.B." was carved in 1998. Gloria Baker (Amond's mother, retired LAUSD 4th-grade teacher, 31 years). Marc's childhood home is now owned by nurse Rosa Delgado (Kaiser, since 2004); the Bullocks moved to Holmby Hills in 2004; Marc promised to replant her roses Mon Aug 12, 8 AM. May 3: lunch with Biden, who gives his 1972 legal pad to Emma. May 10: the twins turn 12. **May 14: Marc formally clinches.** May 18: Clyburn meeting in Columbia, SC (11 pages of notes). **Jun 16 (Father's Day): Cornelius calls Marc and stays on the line 4 min 12 sec.** Jun 24: Trump declines to debate until ratification. Jul 13: Marc calls Trump and suspends ads through the RNC. Jul 16: Jaxon Wilde speaks at the RNC. Jul 27: masked Kang at Comic-Con

(#WhoIsKang). Lyric knew the VP pick from Jul 2 and kept it 38 days (bribed with a promised second dog). VP rollout text to 11.2M phones at 6:00 AM PDT Aug 9. Lyric unveils the "BULLOCK ✦ BAKER" sign: "MY DADDY'S THE VICE PRESIDENT!" Amond: "The job isn't to be important. The job is to be useful." **DNC "Culture's Biggest Night":** an awards-show format; **Robert Bullock as unpaid volunteer creative director**; Donohue not involved; Natasha barred until Thursday ("Fine. I'll buy a ticket"); a live band, celebrity hosts, comedy, an in memoriam; Tyrese return rumors; Grace was the leak. **THE FIX (11 + 1):** 1 universal healthcare (keep private if you like) · 2 universal pre-K–college/trade school · 3 eliminate the $35T debt via the **American Sovereign Fund** · 4 world peace (peace talks within 100 days: Ukraine–Russia, Israel–Palestinians, Taiwan Strait) · 5 domestic peace · 6–7 end inflation and make things affordable (10M homes, insulin and drug caps, free childcare) · 8 superpower (military, chips, AI, union-made cars) · 9 lower taxes, then zero federal income tax for working families (phased in under $100K, then $200K, then everyone, funded by the Sovereign Fund) · 10 clean America (lead pipes, clean energy, a congressional stock-trading ban, no super PACs) · 11 **100% legal immigration** ("no such thing as an illegal immigrant") · **The dream: a North American Union** with Canada and Mexico (talks begin in the first term). Reactions: the Trump campaign, Vance ("buddy comedy," paraphrased), Mexico (AMLO's office; Sheinbaum's team will study it), Canada (cautious). Post-Fix national poll: Bullock 53, Trump 43. **Cornelius's call (Aug 10, 12:31 AM EDT):** strategy notes ("orderly," "secure," "legal"; say "partnership," never "union," in Georgia; "People forgive ambition. They don't forgive arithmetic."), "It was reckless... And it was right," and he'll attend the DNC with the Georgia delegation ("the Georgia roll call should be cast by a Smilley"). **First time he calls Marc "son."** An envelope: "FOR MARC — CHICAGO."

Fictional people introduced: Gloria Baker; Rosa Delgado.

Looming event (in-world): the Democratic National Convention, "Culture's Biggest Night," United Center, Chicago, Mon Aug 19 – Thu Aug 22, 2024. Plus the 28th Amendment ratification race (21/38).